3.7 Topic 5: Bridging the development gap

Development gap	The wealth of traditional and rising superpowers contrasts sharply with the continuing poverty of some peoples and nations. The gap between wealth and poverty can be measured in a variety of ways, but is generally taken to be increasing. A range of theoretical concepts can help explain the geography of the development gap, and its pattern can be illustrated through the study of trade and investment flows. The development gap can be seen in terms of rural and urban divides, and in terms of ethnicity and gender.
Reducing the gap	Development can reduce the gap, and raise people out of poverty, but it often comes with social and environmental costs, and it has not occurred in all locations. The challenge is to begin to reduce the development gap in countries and regions which have so far failed to benefit from the processes of globalisation. There are numerous ways this might be achieved, but there is no universal agreement of which way might be best.

1 The causes of the 'development gap'

Enquiry question: *What is the nature of the 'development gap'? How has it arisen?*

What students need to learn	Suggested teaching and learning
■ The global development gap can be measured by traditional economic indicators (GDP) and broader quality of life indicators (literacy rates, HDI etc). The MDG provide a framework for measuring the development gap and progress towards reducing it.	■ Investigating the advantages and disadvantages of different ways to measure and quantify the development gap.
■ There are a range of theories (eg development, dependency, core/periphery, the role of debt) that can be used to explain the widening gap between developed and developing economies.	■ Developing an awareness that geographical disparities arise from different social, economic and political systems, and an understanding that these allow wealth and advantage to accumulate in unequal ways.

■ Global players and organisations eg World Bank, IMF, TNCs, governments and NGOs have differing roles and contrasting perspectives in relation to the development gap.	■ Examining the role of players and how the actions of some global economic and geopolitical organisations can exacerbate the development gap.
■ Trade and investment play a key role in the development gap, and global wealth distributions; the importance of 'terms of trade', and 'north-south trade flows'. Exemplification of trade patterns in, for example, coffee or bananas in exemplar countries.	■ Developing an understanding of how the global balance of trade maintains the development gap, both now and historically.

2 The consequences of the 'development gap'

Enquiry question: *What are the implications of the 'development gap' at different scales for the world's poorest people?*

What students need to learn	Suggested teaching and learning
■ The development gap has social, economic, environmental and political consequences for people in the most disadvantaged countries – for example sub-Saharan Africa, women and caste divisions in India.	■ Identifying the ways that the development gap results in different impacts upon different people.
■ The development gap is increasingly problematic in developing megacities, where the growth of the urban poor is increasing, for example cities such as Nairobi, Bangkok and rapidly growing cities in Africa.	■ Investigating the growth of megacities and the reasons for the concentration of poverty in these locations.
■ The development gap often has an ethnic and/or religious dimension such as in South Africa, Indonesia and East Timor; and can be associated with migrations, social unrest and new political movements.	■ Investigating how and why social and political unrest can result from geographical disparities in wealth and opportunity.
■ There are positive and negative consequences for countries which are developing and reducing poverty; as development and the environment are rarely compatible unless carefully managed, for example India or China.	■ Weighing the positive (often social and economic) against the negative (often environmental and social) consequences of countries moving out of poverty.